The Secret Behind the Old House

Chapter 1

Mia and her family moved to a small town during the summer. Her father had found a new job there. Her mother was happy because the town was peaceful. However, Mia did not feel the same way. She missed her old friends and her previous school. Their new house was big, but some parts were old. Mia spent most of her time unpacking her things. While looking through her bedroom window, she noticed an old house across the street. The house had broken windows and a rusty gate. Tall plants covered most of its front yard. Nobody seemed to live there. Mia wondered why the house had been abandoned. She asked her mother about it during dinner. Her mother said she did not know anything about the place. That night, Mia kept thinking about the strange house. She felt that there was something unusual about it.

Chapter 2

The next morning, Mia went outside to get some fresh air. She saw an old woman watering plants beside her house. The woman smiled and greeted her warmly. Mia introduced herself and explained that her family had just moved into the neighborhood. The woman introduced herself as Mrs. Clara. They talked about the town and its friendly people. After a while, Mia pointed toward the old house across the street. She asked Mrs. Clara if anyone lived there. The old woman suddenly stopped smiling. She looked at the house with a worried expression. She told Mia to stay away from the place. Mia asked why the house was dangerous. Mrs. Clara only shook her head. Before returning inside, she gave Mia one last warning. She said that some secrets were better left alone. Mia watched her leave and became even more curious.

Chapter 3

Mia's first day at her new school finally arrived. She felt nervous because she did not know anyone. Her teacher introduced her to the class and asked her to sit beside a boy named Ethan. Ethan was friendly and helped her find the correct classroom. During lunch, they talked about their hobbies and favorite subjects. Mia eventually mentioned the old house near her home. Ethan immediately became interested in what she was saying. He explained that a girl named Lily had disappeared twenty years ago. Lily had lived in that same house with her family. Nobody knew exactly what had happened to her. Some people believed that she had run away. Others thought that she had been kidnapped. Ethan said the town still remembered the strange case. Mia remembered Mrs. Clara's warning from the previous day. She wondered if the old woman knew Lily personally. By the end of lunch, Mia wanted to discover the truth.

Chapter 4

After school, Mia asked Ethan where he had learned about Lily. Ethan explained that his grandfather often told him stories about the town. His grandfather had known Lily when they were younger. According to him, Lily was a quiet girl who loved reading books. She rarely talked about her family. One day, she suddenly disappeared without saying goodbye to anyone. Her family moved away shortly after the incident. The police searched the neighborhood but found very little evidence. Mia thought the story sounded suspicious. She asked Ethan if he wanted to investigate the old house. Ethan smiled because he enjoyed solving mysteries. However, he reminded her that entering an abandoned building could be dangerous. Mia agreed that they

should be careful. They decided to visit the house the following afternoon. Before going home, they exchanged phone numbers. Mia felt happy because she had finally made a friend.

Chapter 5

The following afternoon, Mia and Ethan met outside the old house. The sky was cloudy, and the wind moved the dry leaves across the road. They stood near the rusty gate and looked at the building. Ethan tried pushing the gate, but it made a loud creaking sound. Mia looked around to make sure nobody was watching them. They slowly walked through the overgrown garden. The front door was slightly open, which surprised them. Ethan pushed it gently with his hand. The door opened, revealing a dark hallway. They used their phone flashlights to see inside. Dust covered the furniture and the wooden floor. Old family pictures hung crookedly on the walls. Mia noticed a broken clock near the staircase. Suddenly, they heard a loud noise from the second floor. Mia grabbed Ethan's arm and whispered that someone was upstairs. Ethan looked toward the staircase, wondering who else could be inside.

Chapter 6

Mia and Ethan stood silently near the bottom of the stairs. They listened carefully, hoping to hear another sound. A few seconds later, they heard footsteps moving across the upper floor. Ethan called out to ask if anyone was there. Nobody answered his question. Mia suggested that they leave before anything bad happened. Ethan agreed, but he wanted to check the nearby hallway first. They slowly climbed the stairs together. Every step made the old wood creak beneath their feet. At the end of the hallway, they noticed a door moving slightly. Ethan pushed it open while Mia stood behind him. Inside was a small bedroom filled with dusty furniture. An old teddy bear rested on top of a wooden chair. Mia noticed that the window was open. She realized the wind might have caused the strange sounds. However, she still felt that somebody had recently visited the room. Before leaving, Ethan noticed a photograph under the bed.

Chapter 7

Ethan picked up the photograph and wiped away the dust. It showed a young girl standing beside a woman in front of the house. The girl had long hair and a small smile. Mia guessed that the girl was Lily. They turned the photograph over and found a name written on the back. The name was Lily, followed by the date of the picture. Mia wondered who the woman beside her could be. She carefully placed the photograph inside her bag. Ethan continued searching the bedroom for other clues. He found several books stacked inside a broken cabinet. Most of them were children's stories and old schoolbooks. Mia noticed a small drawer beneath the desk. The drawer was locked, but the wood around it was damaged. Ethan carefully pulled it open without breaking anything. Inside, they found an old notebook with a faded cover. Mia opened it and discovered a strange message on one of its pages. The message said, "The truth is buried where the roses grow."

Chapter 8

Mia read the message several times to understand its meaning. Ethan believed it was a clue left by Lily. They wondered why someone would hide the truth beneath roses. Mia remembered seeing rosebushes in the front garden. She suggested that they search the garden before going

home. Ethan agreed and followed her downstairs. They walked outside and examined the plants near the front steps. Most of the garden was covered in weeds and dry leaves. However, several rosebushes still had small flowers. Mia carefully searched around the roots of each plant. Ethan checked the stones surrounding the garden path. After several minutes, he noticed a flat stone beneath a large rosebush. He moved the weeds and saw something metallic underneath it. Together, they lifted the stone from the ground. A small metal box was hidden inside a shallow hole. Mia tried opening it, but the lid would not move. They decided to take it home and find a way to unlock it.

Chapter 9

Mia brought the metal box to her bedroom after returning home. She placed it on her desk and examined its rusty surface. Ethan visited later that afternoon to help her open it. They tried turning the box upside down, but nothing happened. Ethan checked the sides and discovered a small keyhole. Mia remembered the old music box they had seen inside Lily's bedroom. She wondered if its key could fit the metal box. The next day, they returned to the old house after school. They searched the bedroom again, looking carefully through the furniture. Ethan opened the music box on top of the desk. A small golden key was hidden inside it. Mia took the key and hurried back to the metal box. She inserted it into the keyhole and turned it slowly. A clicking sound came from the lock. The box finally opened, revealing several old letters and a folded map. Mia felt excited because they had found another important clue. She wondered what secrets the letters would reveal.

Chapter 10: The

Mia spread the letters across her desk and began reading them. The first letter was written in neat handwriting. It mentioned a family argument that happened many years ago. Another letter described someone hiding important documents inside the house. The writer seemed afraid that the documents would be discovered. Mia thought Lily might have written the letters herself. Ethan noticed that the dates were close to the time of her disappearance. They carefully arranged the letters according to their dates. One letter mentioned a secret room beneath the staircase. Mia remembered the staircase they had climbed during their first visit. She wondered if there was a hidden entrance beneath it. Ethan suggested that they return to the house and investigate. Mia agreed, but she wanted to tell someone where they were going. They informed Mrs. Clara that they would visit the house again. The old woman looked worried but did not stop them. Mia placed the letters and map inside her backpack. The next morning, they prepared to search for the secret room.

Chapter 11

Mia and Ethan arrived at the old house early that afternoon. They entered through the front door and walked toward the staircase. Ethan checked the wooden walls for unusual marks. Mia searched behind the furniture near the bottom steps. They discovered a small wooden panel that looked different from the others. Ethan pressed it gently, and the panel moved inward. Behind it was a narrow door covered in dust. Mia tried turning the handle, but it was stuck. Ethan pushed against the door until it slowly opened. A narrow staircase led down into a dark space. They could barely see anything beyond the first few steps. Mia turned on her flashlight

and began walking carefully. Ethan followed while holding the old map. At the bottom, they found a small room filled with boxes. A wooden table stood in the middle of the room. On the table was an envelope with Lily's name written across it. Mia opened the envelope and began reading the letter inside.

Chapter 12

The letter explained that Lily had discovered a terrible secret about her father. He had hidden documents that proved he was stealing money from other families. Lily wanted to report what she had found to the police. However, she was afraid her father would become angry. She wrote that she had already made plans to leave the house. Mia felt sad while reading the letter. She could not imagine being afraid of someone in her own family. Ethan checked the boxes for more documents. Inside one box, he found several papers covered with signatures. Some papers contained names and amounts of money. Other documents appeared to be copies of financial records. Mia realized that the missing documents were connected to something serious. She placed the papers back inside the box to keep them safe. Suddenly, they heard a noise coming from upstairs. Ethan quickly turned off his flashlight. They stood quietly and listened for footsteps. Someone was moving around inside the house. Mia wondered if the person had followed them.

Chapter 13

The footsteps above them continued for several seconds. Mia and Ethan remained hidden inside the secret room. They heard a door open and close somewhere upstairs. After a while, the house became quiet again. Ethan carefully climbed the stairs to check the hallway. Mia followed him while holding the envelope. They looked through the windows but could not see anyone outside. Ethan suggested that they leave immediately. Mia agreed because she did not want to take any unnecessary risks. Before leaving, she took pictures of the documents with her phone. She hoped the photographs would help them understand the case. On their way out, Mia noticed fresh footprints near the front door. The footprints were larger than hers and Ethan's. They seemed to lead toward the street. Mia told Ethan that someone had visited the house recently. Ethan became worried because they were not the only people searching for Lily's secrets. They hurried home and decided to tell Mrs. Clara what they had discovered.

Chapter 14

Mia and Ethan returned to the neighborhood before sunset. They were about to cross the street when a man approached them. He looked serious and seemed angry about something. The man asked why they had entered the old house. Mia tried explaining that they were researching Lily's disappearance. When he heard Lily's name, his expression suddenly changed. He told them to stop investigating the case. Ethan asked why he cared about their investigation. The man refused to answer and demanded that they return anything they had found. Mia realized that he knew something about the hidden documents. She told him they had not taken anything important. The man stared at them for a moment before walking away. Ethan watched him disappear around the corner. Mia felt nervous because the man's behavior seemed suspicious. They decided to visit Mrs. Clara immediately. They hoped the old woman could explain who the stranger was.

Chapter 15

Mrs. Clara welcomed Mia and Ethan into her living room. She noticed their worried expressions and asked what had happened. Mia told her about the man who had threatened them. She also showed Clara the photographs of the hidden documents. The old woman stared at the pictures for a long time. Finally, she sat down and covered her face with her hands. She explained that she had been Lily's teacher many years ago. Lily had often stayed after class to talk with her. The girl once admitted that she was afraid of her father. Clara had wanted to help her but did not know what to do. She regretted not taking Lily's fears more seriously. Mia asked if Clara knew the man who had threatened them. Clara nodded and said his name was Robert. He was Lily's older brother and had lived in the old house before the family moved away. Clara believed Robert knew more about Lily's disappearance than he had admitted. She warned the children to be careful if they continued investigating.

Chapter 16

The next day, Mia and Ethan met at the local library. They wanted to learn more about Lily's family and the old house. Ethan spread the map across a large table. Mia noticed a small drawing near the edge of the paper. It showed a building beside a forest. A narrow path connected the building to the old house. Mrs. Clara had told them that Lily loved visiting quiet places. Mia wondered if the building had been one of her hiding spots. They searched old town records and found a photograph of the same building. It had once been used as a storage place by a nearby farm. The building had been abandoned for many years. Ethan believed Lily might have gone there after leaving home. Mia agreed that it was worth investigating. They decided to visit the place the following morning. Before leaving the library, they copied the map onto a sheet of paper. Mia felt nervous but hoped the next clue would bring them closer to the truth.

Chapter 17

Mia and Ethan followed the map into the forest the next morning. The path was narrow and covered with fallen leaves. Birds flew between the trees while the wind moved the branches. After walking for several minutes, they saw an old building. Its walls were covered with vines, and several windows were broken. Ethan pushed the front door, which opened with a loud creak. They stepped inside and looked around carefully. Dust covered the floor and the few pieces of furniture left behind. Mia noticed an old blanket lying beside a wooden chair. There were also several empty food cans near the wall. Ethan wondered if someone had stayed there for a long time. He then noticed writing on the wall behind a broken shelf. The message said, "I am safe, but I cannot come home." Mia took a picture of the writing with her phone. She felt hopeful because Lily might have survived after leaving the house. They searched the building for more clues before heading home.

Chapter 18

While searching the abandoned building, Mia noticed a wooden board that looked loose. She knelt down and tried moving it with her fingers. The board came away from the wall without much effort. Behind it was a small space containing an old diary. Mia carefully removed the diary and wiped away the dust. The first few pages contained stories about Lily's childhood. She

wrote about her favorite books, her school, and her dreams. Later entries described her growing fear of her father. Lily explained that she had found the hidden financial documents. She wanted to tell the authorities but feared what her father might do. The last few pages were written in a hurry. Lily said that a kind neighbor had helped her escape. She planned to travel to another town and start a new life. Unfortunately, she never wrote the name of the town. Mia closed the diary and looked at Ethan. They now had evidence that Lily had escaped, but they still did not know where she had gone.

Chapter 19

Mia and Ethan left the abandoned building with the diary safely inside Mia's backpack. They followed the forest path toward the main road. As they reached the trees near the entrance, someone stepped out in front of them. It was Robert, the man who had threatened them before. He demanded that they give him the diary. Mia asked why he wanted something that belonged to his sister. Robert became angry and said they had no right to investigate his family. Ethan told him that the diary could help solve a missing person's case. Robert moved closer and tried grabbing Mia's backpack. She quickly stepped away and shouted for help. Ethan stood between them while Mia ran toward the road. Robert followed for a few steps but stopped when a passing car slowed down. Mia and Ethan hurried toward a nearby shop. They asked the shopkeeper to call the police. Robert disappeared before the officers arrived. Mia was frightened, but she knew they could no longer keep the evidence to themselves.

Chapter 20

Mrs. Clara arrived at the shop after receiving Mia's phone call. She comforted the children and listened to everything they had experienced. Mia showed her the diary and explained Robert's actions. Clara confirmed that Robert was Lily's older brother. She also revealed that their father had once been accused of stealing money. However, the case had ended because there was not enough evidence. The hidden documents might explain what had happened. Ethan believed Robert wanted to destroy the evidence to protect his family. Mia wondered if Robert had helped Lily escape many years ago. Mrs. Clara said she did not know the full story. They agreed that the police needed to examine the diary and documents. Clara also promised to tell the officers everything she remembered about Lily. Mia felt relieved that they no longer had to face the mystery alone. For the first time, she believed the truth might finally come out.

Chapter 21

The following morning, Mia, Ethan, and Mrs. Clara visited the police station. They brought copies of the letters, photographs, and financial documents. Mia explained how they had discovered the hidden room beneath the staircase. Ethan described the abandoned building and showed the officers the map. Mrs. Clara shared what she remembered about Lily's family. The police listened carefully and began recording their statements. An officer explained that the evidence would need to be checked. The police also reopened the investigation into Lily's disappearance. Later that day, officers visited the old house. They searched the secret room and collected the remaining documents. They also questioned Robert about his actions. Robert denied knowing anything about Lily's escape. However, the officers discovered more papers hidden inside his car. The documents matched some of the records found in the old house. Mia

and Ethan hoped this would help the police discover the full truth. They returned home feeling tired but relieved.

Chapter 22

A week passed after Mia and Ethan visited the police station. The investigation continued, but they had not heard any news about Lily. Mia sometimes wondered if they would ever discover where she had gone. One afternoon, Mrs. Clara called Mia and asked her to visit. When Mia arrived, she found Clara holding a small envelope. The letter had arrived from another town. The sender's name was Lily. Clara began crying as she explained what the letter meant. Lily had learned about the reopened investigation through a local news report. She had been living under a different name for many years. She was now ready to explain what had happened. Lily wrote that she had escaped because she feared her father. A kind neighbor had helped her travel to another town. She had stayed away because she wanted to feel safe and build a new life. Mia felt happy knowing Lily was alive. Clara promised to contact the police so Lily could share her story.

Chapter 23

Several weeks later, Lily returned to town to help with the investigation. She arrived at Mrs. Clara's house on a quiet afternoon. Clara immediately hugged her and cried with happiness. Lily looked older than the girl in the photograph, but her smile was familiar. Mia and Ethan arrived shortly afterward. Lily thanked them for finding her diary and protecting the evidence. She explained that leaving home had been the hardest decision of her life. At the time, she felt she had no other choice. She had been afraid that nobody would believe her story. Living in another town gave her time to recover and become independent. Now, she wanted to help the police finish the investigation. Mia asked if Lily was afraid to return to the old house. Lily admitted that she still had painful memories of the place. However, she wanted to face her past instead of running away forever. Ethan told her that she was brave for coming back. Lily smiled and said she was finally ready to begin again.

Chapter 24

Months passed, and the investigation finally reached an important stage. The police confirmed that the hidden documents were connected to the financial crimes. Robert was held responsible for his own actions, while the authorities continued reviewing the family's records. Lily decided to stay in town for a while. She wanted to help the community and reconnect with people from her childhood. With the town's support, the old house was cleaned and repaired. Lily agreed to turn it into a small public library. Volunteers painted the walls and replaced the broken windows. Mia and Ethan helped arrange the books on the shelves. Mrs. Clara donated several books that she had collected over the years. Children began visiting the library after school. The house that once frightened Mia became a place full of laughter and learning. Lily was happy to see children enjoying the rooms where she had once felt lonely. Mia realized that the house had not always been a place of sadness. She learned that knowing the truth could help people heal. From that day on, she understood that even the darkest secrets could lead to a new beginning.